Case study analysis: Student with conduct disorder

Chapter 9: Emotional and behavioral disorders · Katherine Conklin

Student: Name **Grade:** 5th **Classification:** Conduct disorder

The student is in 5th grade and is diagnosed with conduct disorder, a form of emotional and behavioral disorder. He exhibits significant externalizing behaviors, including aggression, defiance, impulsivity, and difficulty following rules. While the student demonstrates grade-level academic ability, his behavioral challenges make learning more difficult for himself and others. This analysis looks at the student's academic and behavioral needs, prioritizes areas for intervention, and outlines evidence-based strategies to support his educational progress within the least restrictive environment.

Academic needs

Strengths

- The student is capable of completing grade-level work when engaged
- He demonstrates strong verbal communication and problem-solving skills in structured settings

Challenges

- Struggles with task completion, often refusing to work when frustrated
- Difficulty following directions and classroom routines, leading to incomplete assignments
- Frequent disciplinary actions (office referrals, suspensions) interrupt academic progress

Behavioral and social needs

- Aggressive behavior toward peers and adults, including verbal and physical altercations
- Defiance toward authority, often refusing to comply with classroom rules
- Impulsivity and lack of emotional regulation, leading to outbursts and disruptions
- Social difficulties, including poor peer relationships and difficulty managing conflicts

Identified triggers

- Unstructured activities (transitions, free play, group work)
- Frustration with difficult assignments or feeling overwhelmed
- Perceived unfair treatment by teachers or peers
- Unexpected changes in routine

Impact on learning

The student's behavioral difficulties limit his ability to engage in classroom activities, disrupt peer interactions, and reduce his instructional time due to disciplinary actions.

Prioritization of academic and behavioral needs

- Behavioral self-regulation: teach the student coping mechanisms to reduce aggression and impulsivity, and implement a structured reinforcement system to encourage positive behavior
- Social skills development: help the student learn appropriate peer interactions, emotional regulation, and conflict resolution through social skills training and peer mediation
- Task completion and engagement in academics: increase on-task behavior with structured routines and behavioral supports, and modify assignments to prevent frustration and avoidance

These three areas must be addressed together to promote academic and social growth.

Specific objectives for the student

Behavioral objectives

Self-regulation goal: By the end of the IEP term, the student will use a designated self-regulation strategy (for example deep breathing, a break card, or counting to 10) in 4 out of 5 observed instances before engaging in aggressive or disruptive behavior.

Social interaction goal: By the end of the IEP term, the student will demonstrate appropriate peer interactions (for example turn-taking and respectful disagreement) in 75% of structured activities, as measured by teacher observations.

Academic objectives

Task completion goal: By the end of the IEP term, the student will complete 80% of assigned classwork across all subjects, with teacher support and behavior management strategies in place.

Classroom behavior goal: By the end of the IEP term, the student will follow classroom rules and teacher directions with minimal redirection in 80% of observed instances.

Evidence-based practices for differentiation

Behavioral interventions

- Behavior intervention plan: provides structured routines, clear expectations, and targeted consequences for behaviors
- Positive behavioral interventions and supports: reinforce desired behaviors through praise, incentives, and structured feedback
- Self-regulation techniques (Zones of Regulation, mindfulness strategies): teach the student to identify emotions and use coping strategies to de-escalate situations

Classroom accommodations and academic support

- Preferential seating and predictable structure: places the student away from distractions and near positive peer models
- Frequent breaks and safe space access: allow the student to reset when overwhelmed before behaviors escalate
- Behavior contracts and checklists: provide clear visual reminders of rules and consequences

- Modified assignments (chunking, step-by-step instructions): prevent academic frustration and refusal behaviors

Social emotional learning

- Social skills training (role playing, peer mediation) teaches appropriate social interactions and emotional regulation
- Small group instruction on emotional regulation helps the student process emotions and practice self-control strategies

Teacher and family collaboration

- Daily check-ins with a trusted staff member reinforce behavioral goals and progress tracking
- Regular parent communication and behavior journals ensure home-school consistency

Final recommendations for intervention

Strengthening the student's IEP

- Update the behavior intervention plan to incorporate new self-regulation strategies
- Include structured peer interaction goals in his IEP to improve social skills and relationships

Increasing classroom support

- Provide teacher training on trauma-informed behavioral strategies to better manage the student's impulsivity and defiance
- Implement a structured behavior contract with rewards for goal achievement

Enhancing family and school collaboration

- Conduct weekly progress reviews with teachers, parents, and support staff
- Encourage the student's participation in school counseling sessions for additional emotional regulation support